

[Author identifying header — name, affiliation, ORCID, email — removed for double-anonymous peer review; will be reinstated upon acceptance.]

June 08, 2026

To the Editorial Team,

Humanities and Social Sciences Communications

Attn: Meenakshi Sundaram, Editorial Support

Dear Editorial Team,

Thank you for the technical-check feedback on Manuscript ID 72427190-7674-4b5f-ac51-9518b8c16eaf (v1.0). I have addressed each of the four points raised. The Declarations block of the manuscript has been revised accordingly; the remainder of the manuscript has been left unchanged in accordance with the editorial instruction.

Point-by-point response.

(1) Consent to Participate declaration. A dedicated "Consent to Participate" subsection has been added to the Declarations section. The subsection states that this study is a systematic review and meta-analysis of previously published quantitative research and did not involve any direct interaction with, or recruitment of, human participants by the present author; informed consent and consent to participate for the underlying data were obtained by the original investigators of each included primary study at the time of original data collection.

(2) Standard / norm referenced in the Ethics declaration. The Ethics Approval subsection now explicitly references the **Declaration of Helsinki** (as revised in 2013) and the **PRISMA 2020** reporting guidelines as the conduct and reporting standards followed by this systematic review and meta-analysis.

(3) Approval Committee / IRB. The Ethics Approval subsection now explicitly states that **no Institutional Review Board (IRB) or Research Ethics Committee approval was required** for the conduct of the present synthesis because no new primary data were collected, and that ethical approval for each of the included primary studies was the responsibility of the original investigators of those studies, as documented in their respective publications.

(4) Human Ethics and Consent to Participate declarations. In addition to the individual subsections (Ethics Approval, Consent to Participate, Consent for Publication), an explicit summary declaration has been added: "**Human Ethics and Consent to Participate Declarations: Not applicable.**"

All four editorial requirements are now satisfied. No other changes have been introduced relative to the previously submitted manuscript file.

Open science. Pre-registration: [OSF preregistration DOI — provided post-acceptance] (OSF Registries, registered 23 April 2026, prior to

formal data extraction). Preprint: [Preprint DOI — provided post-acceptance] (Research Square v1, posted 27 April 2026). Data, analysis code, search logs, screening decisions, risk-of-bias ratings, and supplementary materials are publicly available on the OSF project ([OSF project DOI — provided post-acceptance]), comprising seven separately DOI-tagged components covering protocol, search, screening, extraction, risk of bias, analysis, and the article-level DOI index. A version-controlled mirror is maintained at [Code repository — provided post-acceptance].

Conflict of interest. I declare no financial conflicts of interest. One of my own prior, previously published primary studies — [author's own study], E. (2025), "Who excels in online learning in Japan?", *Frontiers in Psychology*, 16, 1420996 (CC BY, open access; <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2025.1420996>) — is potentially eligible for inclusion; this is addressed transparently through a pre-specified sensitivity analysis excluding the author's own study, which leaves the primary conclusions unchanged ($|\Delta r| < .001$ for every trait, because that study did not contribute extractable zero-order correlations to the primary quantitative pool).

The manuscript has not been published elsewhere and is not under consideration by another journal. The Research Square preprint (v1) is explicitly disclosed above; any substantive revisions during peer review will be reflected in a versioned preprint update under the same DOI stem. I am the sole author and accept full accountability for all aspects of the work.

Thank you for your prompt review of these technical-check items.

Sincerely,

[Author signature removed for double-anonymous peer review.]